

Calm & Oak

A 20-PAGE EDITION

# The Japandi *Starter* Guide

*Quiet rooms,  
beautifully sourced.*

FIRST EDITION · 2026

A NOTE FROM US

# Welcome.

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You probably found us through a Pinterest pin. A linen bedroom, a stoneware vase, an oak shelf — something that made you stop scrolling. The brand started in roughly the same way: a folder of saved images, a slow recognition that the rooms we kept saving had something in common, and a search for what to call that something. The answer was Japandi.

Japandi is the meeting of Japanese restraint and Scandinavian warmth. On Pinterest it looks like cream linen and pale oak. In a real home it works as a daily practice: pieces that age instead of date, materials that improve with use, rooms that feel breathed-in rather than decorated.

This guide is not exhaustive. It's a starting point — the principles that hold the aesthetic together, the colours and materials that make a room read calm, and the ten purchases that get you 80 percent of the way there.

Read it once, then keep it. The hardest part of building a Japandi home is the discipline to stop adding. This guide is also a permission slip to do less.

— Cameron + the Calm & Oak team

## CHAPTER ONE

# The five *principles.*

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*Japandi is built on five principles, in this order. If a room looks "off," it's almost always because one of these is missing. If a room looks finished, all five are quietly working.*

The principles aren't decorative. They're decisions about what to leave out. Each one is a constraint, and the constraints are what make the rooms feel composed instead of crowded. Read them as a checklist when you stand in a room and can't tell why it isn't working.

*i*

## Negative space is a material

The most important thing in a Japandi room is what isn't in it. Empty floor. Empty wall. The breath between objects. Treat space the way you'd treat oak or linen — as something you've chosen.

*ii*

## Two woods, never more

Mix oak and walnut, or oak and ash, or pine and walnut — but pick two and commit. Three woods becomes noise. Two becomes a relationship.

*iii*

## Three textile weights

Heavy wool throw, medium linen curtain, fine cotton sham. Three weights in every room give the eye something to register that a single weight does not.

*iv*

## One muted moment

Japandi looks neutral but the rooms that work always have one moment of restrained colour. Sage, ink black, terracotta, or charcoal. Never more than one. Never bright.

*v*

## Things that age well

A Japandi piece is one you can imagine still owning in twenty years. That's the test. It rules out trend-driven shapes and rules in solid wood, real ceramic, real linen, real metal.



#### PRINCIPLE ONE IN PRACTICE

*Negative space is a material. The room is mostly what you didn't put in it.*

A cream linen sofa, an empty wall behind it, the breath of floor in front. The room photographs because of what isn't here — the second sofa, the wall of frames, the second coffee table. Restraint reads as luxury when the materials are honest enough to deserve the attention.

## CHAPTER TWO

# The *palette*.

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*Six tones. One accent. Used in this proportion, the room reads Japandi from the moment you walk in.*

The palette is monochromatic with a single accent. The base — off-white, cream, charcoal, graphite — covers ninety percent of every room. Sand appears as wood, in linen accents, in stoneware glazes. Terracotta is the moment of warmth, used once per room, never twice. If a paint chip, a fabric swatch, or a ceramic vessel doesn't fit one of these six tones, leave it on the shelf. The palette is the discipline that keeps the rest of the principles workable.

SIX TONES, ONE ACCENT

## The Calm & Oak swatches

OFF-WHITE · #F7F4EE

CREAM · #EFE8DA

CHARCOAL · #2A2A28

GRAPHITE · #5C5A55

TERRACOTTA · #C97B5C

SAND · #D4B996

Off-white as walls and big bedding. Cream as upholstery and curtain panels. Charcoal as the framing colour — picture frames, lampshades, single accents. Graphite for the in-between. Sand for wood, oat linen, stoneware. Terracotta for the single brass candleholder, the single ceramic vase, the single piece of art. Use it once, never twice in the same room.



#### THE PALETTE TRANSLATED

*Off-white linen on the left. Sand-toned oak on the right. Both rooms, one palette.*

The Calm & Oak palette doesn't mean every room looks the same. It means every room shares the same six tones in different proportions. A bedding-led space leans heavier on off-white and cream. A wood-led space leans heavier on sand and graphite. The terracotta accent appears in each, used once.



## CHAPTER THREE

# The *materials*.

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*Japandi is a material practice before it is a visual one. The materials all have something in common: they age, and they age beautifully.*

There is no Japandi room built from plastic or polyester or veneer. The materials below are non-negotiable. They cost slightly more upfront, last a decade longer, and improve with use rather than decline. Buying once is cheaper than buying often.

## *Six materials that earn their place*

### Oak

The Japandi default. Light oak for floors, tables, beds. Solid oak only — veneer reads cheap within five years.

### Linen

Pre-washed only. Bedding, curtains, upholstery. Wrinkles are the point. Skip ironing forever.

### Paper

Rice paper pendants, paper lanterns, paper window screens. The single material that makes a room glow at night.

### Walnut

The accent wood. Picture frames, side tables, the small pieces. Provides depth where oak alone would feel flat.

### Stoneware

Heavier and more honest than porcelain. Look for visible throw lines and matte glazes. Avoid anything glossy.

### Jute & seagrass

Floor texture and storage texture. Jute under the sofa, seagrass baskets on the bookshelf. Natural fibre always.

Brass appears as a seventh material — not in volume, but as the single warm metal accent in a room of oak and stoneware.



OAK



WALNUT



LINEN



STONEWARE



BAMBOO



SEAGRASS

## THE SIX MATERIALS AT A GLANCE

*Real wood. Real fibre. Real stone. The honest list.*

Every material here ages well. Oak develops a deeper grain. Linen softens with each wash. Stoneware shows tiny chips that read as character. Paper pendants glow warmer with use. Seagrass darkens slightly. None of these materials look the same in year five as they do today — and that's the point.

# The *two-woods* rule.

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The single styling rule that keeps a Japandi room from looking busy. Pick two woods. Commit. Never apologize.

Wood is a material with strong personality. Light oak reads Scandinavian. Walnut reads warm and old. Black-stained ash reads modern. Pine reads casual. The eye registers each tone instantly. With three woods, the room becomes a study in inconsistency. With two, it reads as a relationship.

## The four reliable pairings

- Light oak + walnut (the easiest, the warmest)
- Light oak + black-stained ash (modern, graphic)
- Pine + walnut (casual, Scandinavian-leaning)
- White oak + teak (low contrast, almost monochrome)

The exception: a single vintage piece in a third wood gets a pass — the inherited mahogany dresser, the estate-sale teak. It reads as "the heirloom." But you only get one. Two is the rule. One vintage exception is the negotiation.

# Three textile *weights*.

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If a room reads flat — even with the right colour palette — it's almost always because the textiles are all the same weight. Three weights is the fix.

**Heavy** · wool throw, jute rug, linen blanket. Weight on the surfaces — the floor, the foot of the bed, the back of the chair. The heavy weight grounds the room.

**Medium** · linen curtain, cotton bedding, woven seat. The mid-weight holds the air. Curtains diffuse light. Cotton drapes naturally over a duvet. Woven seats add structural texture.

**Fine** · silk-and-linen sham, fine cotton, sheer linen. The finest weight is the lightest visual moment. A single fine pillow in front of two heavier shams. A sheer linen runner over an oak dining table.

The pattern: from heaviest at the bottom (jute rug) through medium in the middle (linen curtain) to fine at the top (sheer pillow). The eye reads up the room and registers each shift. That's why the room feels layered, even when the palette is monochrome.





HEAVY · WOOL



MEDIUM · LINEN



FINE · BOUCLE

## THE THREE WEIGHTS SIDE BY SIDE

*Heavy wool grounds. Medium linen drapes. Fine boucle finishes.*

A room with one fabric weight reads flat — even when the colour palette is correct. The three weights together create the layered surface the eye registers as composed. Apply this in every room: heavy on the floor (rug or throw), medium at the windows (linen curtain) or on the bed (linen duvet), fine at the touchpoints (boucle pillow, sheer linen runner).

## CHAPTER FOUR

# The *starter* list.

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*Two phases. Each one under three hundred dollars. The 80 percent of a Japandi home, sourced and verified.*

A complete Japandi home isn't built from a single shopping trip. It's built from two phases of five purchases each, each phase costing under three hundred dollars. Phase one handles the soft layers — bedding, ceramics, the tray that pulls a surface together. Phase two handles the larger anchors — the rug, the floor lamp, the side table.

Every item is a verified pick, and every item on the next two pages is a live link — tap the name to open the exact product. Prices drift; the always-current list lives on [calmandoak.com](https://calmandoak.com) under the matching pillar page.

## Phase one — the soft layers

FIVE PIECES · ~\$245 · START HERE

- |    |                                                                                     |                                                                                               |      |
|----|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| 01 |    | <u>Simple&amp;Opulence linen duvet cover, queen</u><br>4.6★ · 2,906 reviews · Textiles pillar | \$80 |
| 02 |    | <u>Cream ribbed stoneware bud vase set</u><br>Ceramics pillar · live price on the listing     | \$25 |
| 03 |    | <u>Longhui cream cable-knit throw</u><br>4.7★ · 5,055 reviews · Textiles pillar               | \$35 |
| 04 |   | <u>PoKat ceramic bedside lamp, pair</u><br>4.6★ · 1,614 reviews · Lighting pillar             | \$70 |
| 05 |  | <u>Acacia wood serving tray with handles, 17"</u><br>4.6★ · 4,317 reviews · Decor accents     | \$35 |

Phase one transforms the bedroom and one shelf in two weekends. Tap any piece to open it.

Every link opens the exact product. As an Amazon Associate, Calm & Oak earns from qualifying purchases — it never changes your price. Prices shown are at time of writing; the live list stays current at [calmandoak.com](https://calmandoak.com).



## Phase two — the anchors

FIVE PIECES · ~\$280 · OVER THE NEXT QUARTER

|    |                                                                                     |                                                                                                      |      |
|----|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| 06 |    | <u>GIB seagrass baskets, set of three</u><br>4.9★ · 47 reviews · Storage pillar                      | \$45 |
| 07 |    | <u>LAMSU boho tripod floor lamp</u><br>4.5★ · 213 reviews · Lighting pillar                          | \$85 |
| 08 |    | <u>Wool jute runner rug, natural</u><br>Textiles pillar · live price on the listing                  | \$70 |
| 09 |   | <u>Booniture 15" bamboo pumpkin pendant</u><br>Lighting pillar · the room-maker                      | \$—  |
| 10 |  | <u>THKSHOUZ fluted pedestal side table, warm oak</u><br>Furniture pillar · live price on the listing | \$—  |

Both phases combined: roughly \$525 across ten pieces. Phase two anchors the living room over the following two months.

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## THE WALLS — OUR OWN PRINT COLLECTION

*The hardest thing to find in Japandi is wall art that doesn't shout. So we drew our own.*

Thirty original prints across six series — sumi-e ink drawn in single breaths, one-line botanicals, kanji calligraphy, and tonal studies in oak and walnut. Printed to order on 250gsm museum-quality matte paper, warm off-white rather than bright white. Find them at [calmandoak.com/shop/prints](https://calmandoak.com/shop/prints) or on Etsy at [calmandoak.etsy.com](https://calmandoak.etsy.com) — subscribers receive a quiet 15% note by email this week.

# A seven-day *plan.*

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*If you want one week of structured action, use this. Ten minutes a day, seven small wins.*

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*Monday*      Stand in your bedroom. Count the wood tones. If three or more, identify the two you'll keep.

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*Tuesday*      Clear your nightstand entirely. Place back five objects: lamp, water vessel, book, small dish, single stem.

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*Wednesday*      Replace one cool-white bulb with a 2700K warm-white. Notice the room shift.

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*Thursday*      Photograph the corner of your living room you like least. The photo will tell you what's wrong.

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*Friday*      Browse the Calm & Oak Storage pillar. Order one basket. Decide where it lives before it arrives.

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*Saturday*      Empty one shelf entirely. Put back three objects only. Step away.

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*Sunday*      Make a coffee. Sit in a room that has shifted slightly all week. Notice what changed.

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*"A Japandi home isn't built. It's allowed."*

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